

Ἀνάχαρσις ὁ Σκύθης

Anacharsis the Scythian on Greeks and Barbarians

eul_aid: ars

Period: Ἀρχαϊκή [Archaic](#)
Dialect: Μικτὰι διάλεκτοι [Mixed Dialects \(frg\)](#)
Format: Ἐπιστολή [Epistle](#)

Anacharsis was a Scythian prince and philosopher who lived in the early 6th century BCE. According to the Greek historian Herodotus, he traveled widely in Greece, becoming known in Athens for his wisdom and his outsider's perspective on Greek customs. Herodotus reports that Anacharsis was killed by his own brother after returning home for adopting foreign religious practices.

Later Greek tradition transformed him into a legendary figure. He was included among the mythical Seven Sages of Greece and celebrated as the archetypal "wise barbarian." In this role, his persona was used to critique Greek society, luxury, and complexity from a standpoint of natural virtue and simplicity.

No genuine writings by the historical Anacharsis survive. The works attributed to him were created centuries later by Greek authors. These include a collection of ten letters, which scholars identify as Cynic-era forgeries from the 3rd century BCE or later. These letters and numerous sayings crafted a lasting image of Anacharsis as a moral critic. According to modern scholars, this fictional persona became an important device for Greek self-reflection, allowing philosophers, especially Cynics, to voice social criticism through a respected foreign sage.

Works (1)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Βαρβάρων καὶ Ἑλλήνων · [Fragments on Barbarians and Greeks](#) · 11 passages